of the Khan as one.’

Besides a liberal mind, Bairam possessed a noble disposition, too, as evidenced by the loyalty of his former soldiers, sending him messages of support across enemy lines. There is certainly something both generous and noble about Bairam’s surrender as Badauni describes it.

A young soldier ‘of great beauty . . . and bravery’ died during the battle in the Siwaliks. He was fighting on Akbar’s side, and Bairam’s men brought him the soldier’s head, thinking their commander would be pleased. Instead, Bairam Khan covered his face and wept. The young man had once been in Bairam’s service. ‘A hundred reproaches on this life of mine!’ he exclaimed, that so many like this man had died because of him. But now, no more. Bairam sent a messenger to Akbar, declaring surrender.

Sometime in the autumn of 1560, in the month of Muharram, when Bairam Khan, like Shias across the world, would have been mourning the martyrdom of Imam Husain, the ex-regent prostrated himself before the youthful padishah whom he had guided so well and for so long. By all accounts, the meeting was emotional, perhaps even healing. Bairam fell to the ground, weeping; Akbar raised him up and hugged him, wiped the tears from his cheeks and seated him where the regent always sat in court, to Akbar’s right. They spoke, Akbar talking with ‘kindness and favour’[107] to put Bairam at ease. When they rose, Akbar took off his own robe and gave it to his Khan Baba. Thus, the two men parted. They would never meet again – though only a year later, Akbar would find himself looking after Bairam’s fatherless son, as Bairam had once looked after him.

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Bairam left Akbar’s court, but he may have carried the hope of another change in his fortune. On his way, he had ‘reproached’ one of his old friends, grumbling to him, ‘you forgot all your old obligations’.[108] The man who had kept the Mughal padishah on the Hindustani throne these past five years still had his grudges, his ambitions, and his access to power. He was married to Akbar’s cousin, Salima Begum, a Timurid. In their caravan of travellers to Mecca, he met a Kashmiri widow of Salim Shah Suri’s, with a young daughter. Bairam promptly arranged the marriage of this little Suri princess with his own son. If, in a year or two, Bairam Khan had returned to